now and then of third class travelling. We would then soon see a remarkable change in the conditions of third class travelling and the uncomplaining millions will get some return for the fares they pay under the expectation of being carried from place to place with ordinary creature comforts. [122]

These were strong words from a strong leader.

The railways in India were also a target of revolutionary groups, protests and arson. One such famous incident shook the foundations of the empire.

A DARING TRAIN DACOITY AT KAKORI

On 9 August 1925, the 8 Down train travelling from Shahjahanpur to Lucknow was approaching the town of Kakori (now in Uttar Pradesh), when one of the revolutionaries from the Hindustan Republican Association (HRA) on board the train pulled the alarm chain, bringing the train to a screeching halt.

The train guard, as a normal practice, got down to find out in which compartment the chain had been pulled and why. Two revolutionaries fell on him and made him lie down on his face. Two others pushed the driver from the engine to the ground and stood guard over him. One revolutionary each stood at the end of the train and both fired shots with their pistols, shouting, 'Travellers, do not be afraid. We are revolutionaries fighting for freedom. Your lives, money and honour are safe. But take care not to peep out of the train.'

Four young men entered the guard's van. They managed to push the box to the ground. It had a strong lock. There was an opening on the top; through which they could drop money bags into it. But nothing could be taken out of it. The revolutionaries started dealing blows with hammers to break it open. Ashfaq was the strongest of the group and ran towards the box. He dealt blow after blow on the opening of the box to widen it.

Suddenly they heard the sound of a train coming from Lucknow. One man said, 'Stop firing. Turn down the pistols. Do not strike the box. Ashfaq, wait a little.' The fast-moving train passed by on the other track. After it had passed away, the slit in the box was widened and the money bags were taken out. During this time, all passengers remained quiet, including the British officers, thinking that a big gang of dacoits had attacked the train. The 'dacoits' walked towards Lucknow with the bundles on their head.

Just ten young men had accomplished this difficult job because of their courage, discipline and patience, leadership and, above all, love for the country. They had written a memorable chapter in the history of India's fight for freedom. These revolutionaries were Ramaprasad Bismil, Rajendra Lahiri, Thakur Roshan Singh, Sachindra Bakshi, Chandrasekhar Azad, Keshab Chakravarty, Banwari Lal, Mukundi Lal, Mammathnath Gupt and Ashfaqulla Khan.

Their aim was to get money for their activities, to get some public attention by creating a positive image of the HRA and to shake the British administration.

Following the incident, the British administration started an intense manhunt and arrested several of the revolutionaries. After an 18-month-long case, Pandit Ram Prasad Bismil, Ashfaqulla Khan, Thakur Roshan Singh and Rajendra Nath Lahiri were sentenced to death under sections 121(A), 120(B), 302 and 396 of the Indian Penal Code. Bismil was hanged at Gorakhpur Jail while Ashfaqulla Khan was hanged at the Faizabad Jail and Thakur Roshan Singh at Naini Allahabad Jail. As a mark of respect, today, the Indian